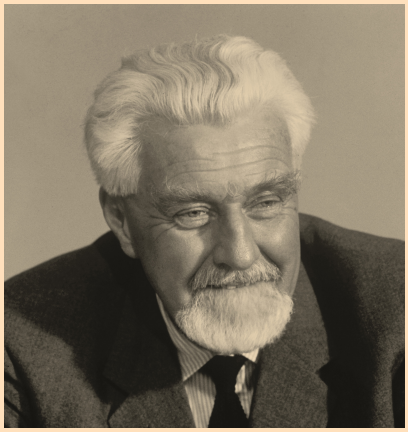
Konrad Lorenz



Born in Vienna, Austria, Lorenz was enthralled by animals from an early age and kept fish, birds, cats, and dogs. The son of an orthopedic surgeon, he studied medicine at Vienna University, graduating in 1928, and gained his Ph.D. in zoology in 1933. His numerous pets became the first subjects of his studies. Lorenz is perhaps best known for describing the phenomenon known as “imprinting.” This is when a newly hatched chick bonds with the first thing it sees (usually its parent) and will follow it around. The behavior, seen in ducks and other birds, as well as mammals, is instinctive and occurs shortly after birth. Lorenz demonstrated the theory by quacking like a duck at newly hatched ducklings. He soon had a flock of ducklings that followed him everywhere.

Key works

1952 *King Solomon’s Ring: New Light on Animal Ways*

1949 *Man Meets Dog*

1963 *On Aggression*

1981 *The Foundations for Ethology*

See also: The selfish gene • Field experiments • Keystone species • Animal ecology • Clutch control • Using animal models to understand human behavior • Thermoregulation in insects